University of Michigan
Institute for Social Research
Center for Political Studies
Ann Arbor, MI

Tyler Simko

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Academic Positions

University of Michigan
- Assistant Professor of Political Science (2025 - Present)
- Assistant Professor of Public Policy (by courtesy, 2025 - Present)
- Faculty Associate, Center for Political Studies (2025 - Present)
- Faculty Affiliate, Better Government Lab (2025 - Present)

Princeton University
- Postdoctoral Research Associate (2024-2025), Department of Politics

Education

Harvard University
- **Ph.D. in Government** (2024)
  - *Dissertation*: "Geographic Policy Evaluation in US State and Local Politics"
  - *Fields:* American Politics, Quantitative Methods
  - *Committee:* Kosuke Imai (chair), Stephen Ansolabehere, Martin West, Justin de Benedictis-Kessner

- **Affiliations:**
  - The Algorithm-Assisted Redistricting Methodology Project, (ALARM)
  - Center for American Political Studies (CAPS)
  - Program in Education Policy & Governance (PEPG, Harvard Kennedy School)
  - Harvard Mellon Urban Initiative Fellow 2023-2024 (HMUI, Harvard Kennedy School)

Princeton University
- **A.B. in Politics** (2018)
  - *Fields:* American Politics & Quantitative Analysis
  - *Certificates*: Statistics & Machine Learning
- **Streicker Fellow** (2017): The University of Tokyo

Published Research

2026 ———

1. "Alleviating Administrative Burdens in Rental Assistance Promotes Access and Program Efficiency," with Rebecca Johnson. *PNAS*. Accepted.
2. "Redistricting Reforms Reduce Gerrymandering by Constraining Partisan Actors," with Cory McCartan, Christopher T. Kenny, Emma Ebowe, Michael Y. Zhao, and Kosuke Imai. *American Political Science Review*, Forthcoming. 2026.
3. "City Racial Segregation Statistics are Robust to Aggregation Bias" with Jacob Brown and Christopher Kenny. *Nature: Cities*. Accepted.

2025 ———

4. “Tabling Debates: How Local Officials Use Agenda Control to Stifle Conflict,” with Mirya Holman. *Legislative Studies Quarterly*. 2025.
5. “Measuring Conflict in Local Politics,” with Mirya Holman and Rebecca Johnson. *Urban Affairs Review*. 2025.
    - **Award**: APSA 2024-25 Best Paper in Education Politics and Policy
    - **Award:** APSA 2024-25 Best Paper in Urban and Local Politics, Honorable Mention
    - **Coverage:** Associated Press, ABC News, EducationWeek
6. "City-Defined Neighborhood Boundaries in the United States” with Stephen Ansolabehere, Jacob R. Brown, Ryan D. Enos, Ben Shair, and David Sutton. *Nature: Scientific Data* 12, no. 1: 1-8. 2025.
7. “A community-driven optimization framework for redrawing school attendance boundaries,” with Hongzhao Guan, Paul Riggins, Jasmine Mangat, Cassandra Moe, Urooj Haider, Frank Pantano, Effie McMillian, Genevieve Siegel-Hawley, Pascal Van Hentenryck, and Nabeel Gillani. *Proceedings, 2025 ACM Conference on Equity and Access in Algorithms, Mechanisms, and Optimization* (EAAMO). 2025.
8. “Contextual Stochastic Optimization for School Desegregation Policymaking,” with Hongzhao Guan, Nabeel Gillani, Jasmine Mangat, and Pascal Van Hentenryck. *Proceedings of the 2025 AAAI Conference on Artificial Intelligence* (AAAI). 2025.

2024 ———

9. "A summer bridge program for first-generation low-income students stretches academic ambitions with no adverse impacts on first-year GPA,” with Rebecca Johnson and Kosuke Imai. *PNAS*, 121 (50) e2404924121. 2024.
10. "The Promise of Text, Audio, and Video Data for the Study of US Local Politics and Federalism," with Soubhik Barari. *Publius: The Journal of Federalism*, pjae046. 2024.
11. “School desegregation by redrawing district boundaries.” *Nature: Scientific Reports* 14, 22097. 2024.
    - **Award:** MPSA 2024 Robert H. Durr Award, for “the best paper applying quantitative methods to a substantive problem.”
    - **Coverage**: New Jersey State Policy Lab at Rutgers University, Harvard University Graduate School of Arts & Sciences
12. “Evaluating bias and noise induced by the U.S. Census Bureau’s privacy protection methods” with Christopher T. Kenny, Cory McCartan, Shiro Kuriwaki, and Kosuke Imai. *Science Advances*, Vol. 10, eadl2524. 2024.
    - **Coverage**: Science Insider, Election Law Blog
13. “How academics and policymakers can collaborate effectively: Lessons from using behavioral science to improve U.S. federal government policies” with members of The Office of Evaluation Sciences. *Behavioral Science & Policy*. 2024.
    - with Shibeal O’Flaherty, Lizzie Martin, Syon Bhanot, Crystal Hall, Sebastian Jilke, and Mary Steffel.
14. “Census officials must constructively engage with independent evaluations” with Christopher T. Kenny, Cory McCartan, and Kosuke Imai. *PNAS*, 121 (11) e2321196121. 2024.
    - Response to Jarmin et al. (2023)

2023 ———

15. “Making Differential Privacy Work for Census Data Users” with Cory McCartan and Kosuke Imai. *Harvard Data Science Review*, *5*(4). 2023.
16. “Widespread partisan gerrymandering mostly cancels nationally, but reduces electoral competition” with Christopher T. Kenny, Cory McCartan, Shiro Kuriwaki, and Kosuke Imai. *PNAS*, 120 (25) e2217322120. 2023.
    - **Coverage:** Yale Institution for Social and Policy Studies
17. “Researchers need better access to US Census data” with Cory McCartan and Kosuke Imai. *Science* 380, no. 6648, 902-903. 2023.
18. “LocalView, a database of public meetings for the study of local politics and policy-making in the United States” with Soubhik Barari. *Nature: Scientific Data* 10, no. 1, 135. 2023.
    - **Project website**: LocalView.net
    - **Coverage**: Nature Social & Behavioral Sciences Blog.

19. "The Essential Role of Policy Evaluation for the 2020 Census Disclosure Avoidance System" with Christopher T. Kenny, Shiro Kuriwaki, Cory McCartan, Evan T.R. Rosenman, and Kosuke Imai. *Harvard Data Science Review*, Special Issue 2. 2023.

2022 ———

20. "Simulated redistricting plans for the analysis and evaluation of redistricting in the United States" with Cory McCartan, Christopher T. Kenny, George Garcia III, Kevin Wang, Melissa Wu, Shiro Kuriwaki, and Kosuke Imai. *Nature: Scientific Data* 9, no. 1, 689. 2022.
    - **Coverage**: The New York Times, Brennan Center, "How Gerrymandering Tilts the 2024 Race for the House."
21. "The Use of Differential Privacy for Census Data and its Impact on Redistricting: The Case of the 2020 U.S. Census" with Christopher T. Kenny, Shiro Kuriwaki, Cory McCartan, Evan T.R. Rosenman, and Kosuke Imai. *Science Advances*, Vol. 7, eabk3283. 2022.
    - **Selected Coverage**: Associated Press, The Washington Post, San Francisco Chronicle, etc.
    - Originally submitted as a public comment to the US Census Bureau (5/28/2021)
22. "Presidential Patronage and Executive Branch Appointments, 1925–1959" with Jon Rogowski. *Presidential Studies Quarterly* 52, no. 1: 38-59. 2022.

Working Papers

1. "A Pipeline for Extracting Data from Videos of Complex Political Events," with Andreas Küpfer and Mirya Holman. socArXiv. Under Review.
2. "Local Governments and Symbolic Representation," with Taran Samarth. OSF. Under Review.
3. "Using Large-Scale Data to Monitor Conditions in New York City Public Housing." with Rebecca Johnson and Josh Grossman. with OES. Project Page.

Policy Reports, Public Engagement, & Other Writing

1. Mikie Sherrill landslide in New Jersey driven by high turnout, with Kabir Khanna, **CBS News**. 2025.
2. UMich community reacts to California's Prop 50 approval. **Michigan Daily**, 2025.
3. Trump's proposed snap Census won't get him the seats he wants with Chris Kenny, **The Hill**. 2025
4. Republicans are seeking to create a durable gerrymander in Texas with Ben Schneer and Max Palmer. **San Antonio Express-News**. 2025
5. Streamlining income verification to broaden access to rental assistance. **Office of Evaluation Sciences** report. 2024.
    - Partnership: US Department of Treasury and Kentucky Housing Corporation.
6. Reducing documentation burdens to accelerate and broaden access to emergency rental assistance. **Office of Evaluation Sciences** report. 2024.
    - Partnership: US Department of Treasury and Virginia Department of Housing and Community Development.
7. Three reasons why NJ should cut the 'county line' from ballots with Nicholas Stephanopoulos. **NJSpotlight News**. 2024.

Teaching

POLSCI797: Machine Learning and Complex Data for Political Scientists
Fall 2025. New graduate course.

POLSCI489: Urban and Local Politics
Fall 2025. New undergraduate course.

- Teaching experience pre-2025 available upon request.

Honors, Grants, and Awards

- **APSA Best Paper in Education Politics and Policy** (2024-25)
- **APSA Best Paper in Urban and Local Politics, Honorable Mention** (2024-25)
- **MPSA Robert H. Durr Award**, for "the best paper applying quantitative methods to a substantive problem" (2024)
- **Robert Noxon Toppan Prize,** Harvard University Department of Government, for best dissertation on a subject of political science (2024)
- **Fostering Diverse Schools Grant**, US Department of Education. Partnership with Winston-Salem/Forsyth County Schools and Plural Connections Group. Co-investigator $200,00 (2024-2025)
- **C-SPAN Scholarship & Engagement (CCSE), Video Research Institute:** Selected Researcher (2024)
- **Office of Evaluation Sciences,** General Services Administration (GSA) Interpersonnel Act Agreement (2022-2024)
- **Harvard Mellon Urban Initiative,** Doctoral Fellowship (2023-2024)
- **Derek C Bok Award for Excellence in Graduate Student Teaching of Undergraduates**, Harvard University (2023)
- **Georgetown McCourt Tech & Public Policy (TPP) Grant.** *Using Large-Scale Video, Text, and Legacy/Social Media Data to Understand and Reduce Polarization in Local Governance*. Co-investigator. $215,000 (2023-24)
- **Harvard Mellon Urban Initiative**, Research Grant (2023)
- **Department of Government MVP All-Star Teaching Award**, Harvard University (2021)
- **Certificate of Distinction in Teaching**, Harvard University (Fall 2020, Spring 2021, Fall 2021, Spring 2022)
- **Center for American Political Studies** Research Grant, Harvard University. Co-Investigator. (2019)
- **Streicker International Fellowship**, Princeton University (2018)

Recent Presentations

Invited:

- **University of Michigan,** School of Information: 2026
- **Better Government Lab,** McCourt / Ford School of Public Policy: 2025
- **The University of Chicago** American Politics Conference: 2025
- **University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill** Methods and Design: 2025
- **Princeton University** Center for the Study of Democratic Politics (CSDP): 2025
- **New York University** Responsible Data Science: 2025
- **Princeton University** Invited Conference**:** 2025
- **Hertie School** Data Science Lab: 2024
- **MZES (University of Mannheim)** Social Science Data Lab: 2024
- **Princeton University** Data Driven Social Science Initiative: 2024
- **Northeastern University** Center for Design: 2024
- **Southern Education Foundation** Issues Forum: 2023
- **Dartmouth College** Lectures on Politics and AI: 2023
- **Northeastern University** Plural Connections Group: 2023
- **Harvard University** Gov 97: Drawing Democracies: 2023

Conferences:

- **American Political Science Association**: 2025, 2024, 2023
- **Local Political Economy Conference**: 2025, 2024, 2023
- **Midwest Political Science Association:** 2026, 2025, 2024
- **Southern Political Science Association:** 2025
- **Society for Political Methodology**: 2025, 2024, 2023
- **State Politics and Policy:** 2025
- **Politics and Gender:** 2025

- **American Educational Research Association**: 2024
- **Council for European Studies**: 2024

Government Experience

- **General Services Administration**: Office of Evaluation Sciences, Data Scientist: 2022-2024
- **South Amboy (NJ) Board of Education**: Member and President: 2013-2018